
ADVISORY COMMITTEE'S RECOMMENDATION

Recommendation: FAVORABLE ACTION on Article 9 by a vote of 15-0-0.

The Advisory Committee has reviewed the proposed appropriations for FY2026 and is pleased to present this report to Town Meeting. Since February of 2025, the Committee and its subcommittees have conducted well-attended public hearings with the Town's department heads and the leadership of the Public Schools of Brookline. By a vote of 15-0-0 the Advisory Committee recommends FAVORABLE ACTION on the FY2026 budget. The full motion follows this report.

We thank all of the people who assisted in this year's process, including (but not limited to) the Select Board, Town Administrator, Deputy Town Administrator, Assistant Town Administrator, the Administrative Services Director, School Committee, and Town department heads. Particular thanks are extended to Deputy Town Administrator Melissa Goff, Assistant Town Administrator Charles Young, and Finance Director Lincoln Heineman for their time and patience and their willingness to answer the Committee's many questions. Special thanks should be given to all of the citizens of Brookline who volunteer their time and effort to serve on committees or attend the countless hearings and meetings which are necessary for this planning.

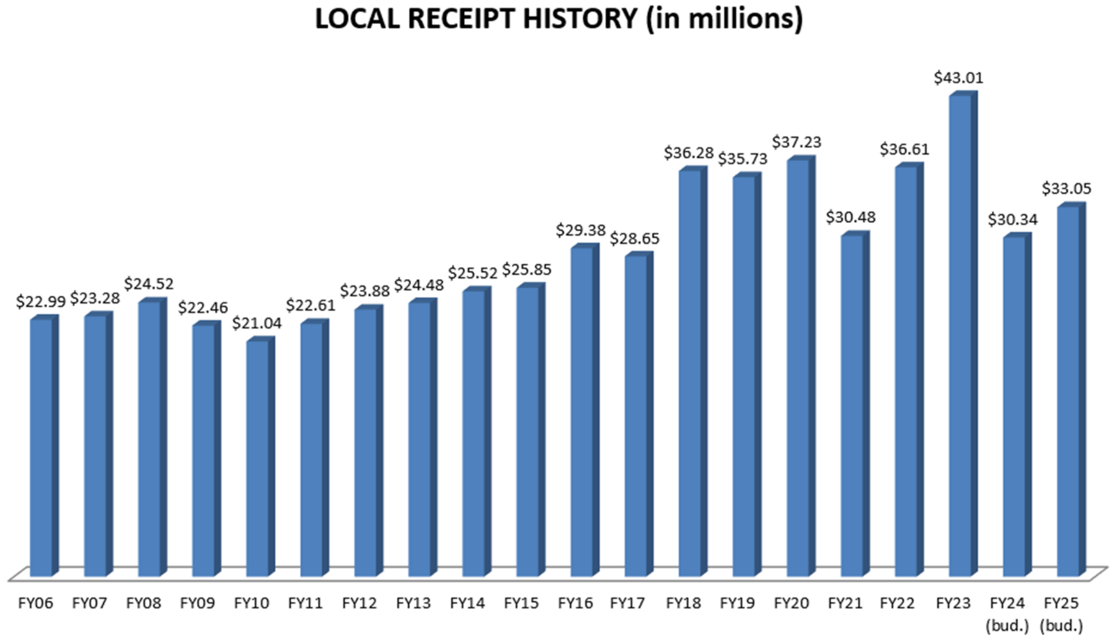
DISCUSSION

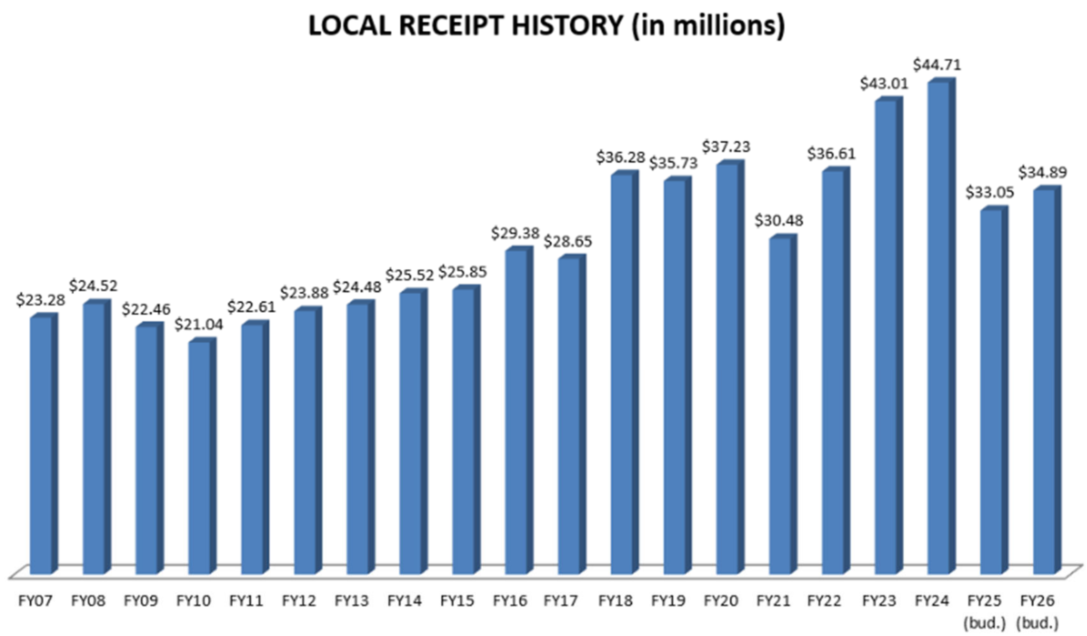
The FY2026 main budget motion is $408,222,486, a 4.6% increase from FY2025. This is comprised of the allowable 2.5% growth under Proposition 2 1/2, additional growth from the final year of the override that was passed in 2023, and close to $2.5M in new growth (from new construction). Unrestricted General Government Aid increased by 2.2%. (By way of comparison, this aid increased 3% in FY2025.)

All of the information to be shared in this report, including the Town Administrator's budget message, can be found in interactive form online and we recommend that you explore it in detail. (Start on the Town's home page at http://brooklinema.gov/ and follow the navigation links to "Open Government.")

Revenues

Local receipts have almost completely rebounded to their pre-pandemic numbers. The estimate for FY2026 is 5.6% higher than the estimate for FY2025; however it should be noted that the increase (over estimate) for FY25 was 10.1%. Lodging and meals excise taxes continue to modestly increase while the Marijuana Excise Tax has leveled off at approximately $300,000. For FY2026 the Town is increasing the Pay As You Throw refuse and recycling fees, recommended by the Solid Waste Advisory Committee, resulting in approximately a 12% increase in the fees generated by this program.





A total of $24M in Free Cash has been certified. Free Cash is generated when the actual operating results compare favorably with the budget, such as when actual revenues exceed the original estimates and/or when actual expenditures are less than appropriated. It is also affected by increases or decreases in uncollected property taxes, non-General Fund deficit balances, and any other legally incurred operating deficits. The certified Free Cash number this year is again significantly higher than usual, due primarily to unexpectedly high returns from the Town's investments. It is unrealistic to expect this trend to continue. As per best practice, Free Cash will not be allocated for operational expenses. This amount of Free Cash allows us to shore up the Liability Reserve (which had been called upon to address a Police Department settlement), the Affordable Housing Trust, continue to achieve our goal of having at least 10% of prior year net revenue allocated to reserves, and fund over $14M of Capital Improvement Projects, the details of which will be discussed later.

Expenses
The full set of departmental allocations is broken out in the budget resolution; this report will focus on selected areas of interest. We repeat the table we included last year, showing spending for selected departments over the past 6 budget cycles. Below we address some specific departmental budgetary concerns.

	FY21 ACTUAL	FY22 ACTUAL	FY23 ACTUAL	FY24 BUDGET	FY25 BUDGET	FY26 BUDGET
Police	$17,386,626	$17,493,030	$17,442,761	$19,560,590	$19,167,445	$21,040,066
Fire	$15,951,670	$16,481,472	$17,541,954	$18,854,944	$19,144,688	$19,240,336
Building	$8,831,246	$9,587,404	$10,649,313	$11,196,910	$12,261,034	$12,334,359
Public Works	$16,008,198	$16,668,234	$16,608,450	$18,355,326	$18,813,556	$20,565,454
Schools	$120,748,990	$119,870,476	$121,600,027	$130,702,376	$136,847,619	$142,310,953

Selected Department Expenses Over Time

Building. Close readers of this report will recall that for the past several budget cycles we have encouraged an appropriate allocation of funds for building maintenance. The size of the Town's building footprint is estimated at over $1B and for many years the budget for building maintenance was not increasing as quickly as the value of the underlying building. This was remedied in the last few budgets (the large year-over-year increases shown above were almost entirely due to increased expenditures on building maintenance). The "new baseline" for building maintenance is largely unchanged, with the notable exception that in order to address a shortfall in the Public Schools of Brookline (PSB) budget, $162,499 that was earmarked for largely cosmetic maintenance for school buildings has been relocated from the FY2026 Building Department budget to the PSB operating budget. This recommendation, which was extensively debated at the Town-School Partnership (TSP), was not made lightly. Cannibalizing routine maintenance, even for seemingly cosmetic items such as painting or window cleaning, is not recommended and is certainly not a pattern we would like to see repeated.

Schools. The largest single allocation in the budget is for the Public Schools of Brookline. The School Department's budget is recommended to be funded at $142,310,953, a 3.8% increase from FY2025. The School Department will supplement these funds via its revolving and gift funds, and the use of federal, state, and private grants and funds. This amount is equal to the PSB's allocation from the TSP (and also what the School Committee voted on May 1, 2025).

The Town Administrator's budget message from February 14th, 2025, stated the School Department's preliminary budget estimate for FY2026 exceeded its TSP revenue allocation by more than $8M. It also discussed a potential significant shortfall in FY2025. Near the end of 2024 the School Department found itself facing allegations of fiscal mismanagement. The TSP, Advisory Committee, and School Committee each recommended engaging external consultants to review the budgets and processes of the School Department. As of the time of this writing, the findings from the review have not been published, but it is anticipated they will be when Town Meeting commences. We hope that the findings and associated recommendations will both 'clear the air' and provide guidance for the Town and the PSB regarding further development of budget and control best practices.

The Advisory Committee appreciates the difficult decisions made by both the administration and the School Committee to bring the budget request in line with the TSP allocation. The School Committee (with support from the TSP) voted to allocate $1,943,064 of out of district special education tuition expenses from its budget to to the "Circuit Breaker" Revolving Fund. Circuit Breaker funds are anticipated State receipts for Special Education). And, along with the building maintenance item referenced earlier, the TSP recommended delaying the design phase of the new Lincoln School playground and allocating that $970,000 to the contingency fund in the event that it may be needed for the FY2026 school budget. It is hoped that neither of these reserve measures will have to be fully tapped.

Special education expenses are incredibly volatile and, like snow removal costs, cannot be fully anticipated when developing a budget. But, like snow removal, the expenses must be incurred when they happen. We anticipate additional budgetary changes, potentially including establishing a Special Education Reserve Fund, after the fiscal review mentioned above is completed. It should also be noted that the Expenditures and Revenues Study Committee is expected to offer recommendations, some of which will touch upon the PSB budget, later this calendar year.

In our report last year, the Advisory Committee expressed its concern that more rapid progress could be achieved in several areas that would enhance transparency and let Town Meeting and taxpayers have insight into progress on a number of issues. With one exception noted below, we have yet to see progress on these items:

1. **Metrics.** The PSB has not presented a coherent set of metrics that can be tied to the PSB's stated operational goals and used to measure system progress. This is particularly important now that the PSB has completed its Strategic Plan. The PSB should have ***clearly articulated*** metrics by which it defines success and those metrics should require advancement beyond what existed in Brookline pre-Covid;
2. **Achievement Gap.** The PSB has not articulated a clear plan for how it will address the long-standing gap between the achievement of White and Asian students compared to that of Black and Hispanic students;
3. **Multi-year financial projections.** Though there are reasons this may not have been done this year, the Advisory Committee emphasizes the need for multi-year projections. This is a 'best practice' and one the Town employs when preparing its budget and reports. To not have similar information for the Town's largest consumer of financial resources is problematic. All constituents are entitled to understand and consider the potential fiscal impact and resource demands the PSB is considering and, related;
4. **Continuity of Information/Tie Actions to Research and Plans.** The PSB has a strategic plan. The PSB has undertaken significant research, including investment in

studies conducted by outside consultants. The Advisory Committee recommends the PSB try each year to tie what it is doing back to specific recommendations from those research and planning efforts so that the community can more easily understand "where the PSB is going."

The exception worth noting is that with respect to items 3 and 4, the PSB has significantly improved aspects of its fiscal accounting. The budget shortfalls noted by the Town Administrator's budget message in February were, after all, well known in February, which represents an improvement over prior years.

Last year we noted that the PSB has endured significant leadership turmoil over the past ten years. This has continued into 2025 with the recently announced departure of the Superintendent and the turnover in the Office of Student Services. We know the School Committee shares our concern about the impact constant leadership change can have on staff, families and budget discipline. We would like to thank Dr. Guillory for his work with the PSB and the development of a strategic plan to address shortcomings identified. We wish him the best in his future endeavors.

Public Works. The Public Works Departmental (DPW) budget for FY2026 is $20,565,454, an 8.5% increase over FY2025. A portion of this increase is due to increased costs (as much as $415,000 in FY2026) associated with privatizing solid waste collection. While the Advisory Committee was quite supportive of the rest of the DPW budget and the fine work of Commissioner Chute and her staff, there were many questions regarding the outsourcing of this function. The Advisory Committee chair appointed an ad hoc subcommittee to review the impacts of privatizing solid waste collection. This subcommittee held a public meeting and a public hearing in order to evaluate several aspects, including comparative cost analysis, employee retention, service delivery quality, and future options for trash collection. Commissioner Chute and her management team feel strongly that outsourcing solid waste collection is the proper solution to the chronic problem of understaffing within the Sanitation division which has led to morale issues both within the division as well as throughout DPW as workers from other divisions have been called in to address staffing shortages. They do not come to this decision lightly; in fact the Department engaged in a pilot program intended to alter the working environment for sanitation workers in an attempt to improve morale. In the Department's opinion, this program, which they had high hopes for, failed, leaving the privatization initiative as the best available alternative.

The full report from the ad hoc subcommittee can be found here and is a fascinating read. The subcommittee, by a vote of 3-0-2 recommended that the Town seek a 1-year extension of its existing solid waste program and explore options to alter the compensation for sanitation workers in an attempt to retain the existing methods of trash removal.

The full Advisory Committee (by a vote of 8-13-2), however, rejected this recommendation and recommends funding the DPW budget as presented, including the outsourcing of solid waste collection.

During the review of the DPW budget there were also concerns raised about how the recently enacted Tree Preservation by-law would be enforced. Initial answers led Committee members to believe that the Department would be unable to effectively enforce the by-law despite the clear message from Town Meeting. During a followup meeting on April 17, 2025, Commissioner Chute presented the detailed timeline for rolling out enforcement which satisfied those concerns. A number of steps remain in the timeline, including updating Accela and permit forms, hiring and training staff, updating the website, and holding a public hearing on the new rules and regulations.

Police. The Police Department budget for FY2026 is $21,040,066, an increase of 8.9% over FY2025. As noted last year, the Department is operating with a new four-year contract between the Town and the police union, which brought an overall 18% pay increase plus new Steps. This contract also allowed the Town to leave Civil Service. The terms of the contract were frontloaded; this is the second year of that front loading. 6 open FTE positions were held (unfilled) in FY2025; this continues into FY2026. This results in a cost savings that helps fund the contract; we hope that these positions will be filled in FY2027.

The Department currently has 10 vacancies (the 6 "held" positions and 4 others). This results in 122 officers on duty, of which 3 are out on long-term leave, 4 out for on-the-job injuries or medial reasons. Additionally, we can expect some attrition during the year. However, we have good news to report. The Department has been able to hire 16 new officers, 9 of which were lateral transfers. After years of watching officers leave the Town for other venues, it is heartening to see both new and experienced officers wanting to work for Brookline. This is evidence that the changes which were put in place last year appear to be working.

Despite the new hires, overtime numbers are paradoxically up. The answer to why this is is still being investigated; speculation includes that officers are spending down vacation and personal time accrued during the past few years when we were short-staffed.

It should be noted that there is a proposal to restore School Resource Officers into the public schools. This is an open policy decision about which we are not offering an opinion; however Town Meeting should be aware that should this program be restored it can be implemented without requiring new hires.

As we noted for the past several years, the training budget for the department has been a concern. The FY2026 budget includes 52 hours of mandatory training.

Fire. The Fire Department (BFD) budget for FY2026 is $19,240,336, an increase of 0.5%. In FY2025 the budget for overtime pay was increased by $300,000 to attempt to more accurately reflect actual overtime claims. This number remains elevated in FY2026 but is probably insufficient to fully cover overtime costs. The primary driver of overtime in the BFD is leave use, which is up 4.7% over last year. The increases are in A-Days (Administrative or Personal days), Injuries, and Sick days. The Assistant Town Administrator for Finance has engaged in an analysis to attempt to understand the contributing factors. A memorandum from March 11, 2025 outlines some of the findings. Most notable is leave being taken on weekends and around holidays. Sick leave, for example, is nearly 50% higher on Saturday that in the middle of the week. Sick leave often occurs around holidays (although typically not on the holiday itself, which has special payment restrictions). The most expensive day for leave in FY2024 was the Friday before Labor Day. The Assistant Town Administrator believes that adjusting the minimum staffing requirements to be consistent with surrounding communities (excepting Boston) would give the Chief the flexibility to call in extra staff for overtime less frequently without affecting the size of the workforce or compromising public safety. The Firefighters Union is currently engaging in its own study for which a report should be available shortly.

The full complement of 161 FTEs is funded in the budget. There are currently 4 vacancies in the department with a retirement pending. There are three recruits in the pipeline which will leave two vacancies once the retirement goes through.

Over the past 10 years, the number of 911 calls that the Fire Department responds to has increased by approximately 200 per year. The majority of the increase is for emergency medical assistance. In FY2025 the number of emergency calls was estimated at 10,150, increasing to 10,350 in FY2026.

Renovations of Fire Stations
The project is proceeding according to the 5-7 year timetable although the start date was delayed by staffing changes in the Building Department. The Fire Department, working together with the Building Commission, reviewed bids and selected the firm Cambridge 7 Group to provide architectural designs and overall project management for the first 2 stations to be renovated: Fire Station 1, located at 40 Washington Street in Brookline Village, and Fire Station 4, located at 827 Boylston Street between Hammond Street and Chestnut Hill Avenue. The bid documents have now been completed for Station 4 and the general contractor is expecting the 8-12 month renovation to begin this Fall. While that station is under renovation, the second renovation (Station 1) will be teed up to start at the completion of Station 4. After that will be a complete rebuild of Station 5 (likely to start in 2028). Station 5, located at 49 Babcock Street in Coolidge Corner, is the only fire station in Brookline that does not have facilities for women firefighters.

The Cambridge 7 Group developed cost estimates for the entire project, which consists of 4 firehouse renovations and 1 rebuild. The cost has increased considerably since the time of the original estimate of $60-65M, due to inflation and the installation of fossil fuel free (FFF) energy sources. Geothermal HVAC is proving to be too costly and so the Town is going with a high-efficiency mid-level FFF alternative that will, hopefully, continue to receive some Federal and State incentives. Given projections based on information known at this point, the current funding should cover the cost of construction for the first four stations, with cost only becoming an issue when the last station is slated to be renovated. Chief Sullivan cautioned that there could be various factors that would alter these cost projections, such as the implementation of high tariffs. Station 7 on Washington Street in Washington Square is the last to be renovated and at that point a decision will be made to either renovate or rebuild it. The ballot question that was approved by the voters in 2022 had no dollar amount; however, any increase in funds will need Town Meeting approval, given that Town Meeting voted on an amount of $65M.

Veterans' Services. Last year the Advisory Committee indicated its concern regarding the Veterans' Services department head's practice of occasionally transporting veterans in his personal vehicle, so much so that the subcommittee engaged with Town Counsel to help understand the risks involved. We are very happy to report that the Department has acquired its own (electric) vehicle that has addressed this concern. Additionally, the Department has stepped up its efforts to conduct outreach to underserved veterans.

Capital Improvement Plan
The amount of funding for Brookline's Capital Improvement Program (CIP) is, by policy, determined to be 6% of the prior year's net revenue (4.5% debt financed, i.e., funds that are raised and paid for within the property tax levy, and 1.5% revenue financed), plus sufficient funds from Free Cash to reach 7.5% of the prior year's net revenue. It should be noted that debt service for Water and Sewer projects and Golf Course projects is paid for by the revenue streams of the Water and Sewer Enterprise Fund and the Golf Course Enterprise Fund.

The 2025 Annual Town Meeting will be asked to vote on a revenue financed CIP for FY2026 that totals $19,374,148 and bond authorizations totaling $6,900,000.
Details and explanations for the CIP requests the Advisory Committee recommends funding can be found later in this report. Please note that the Committee's recommendation for certain items diverges from what was originally proposed.

General Comments
In our report last year in these pages, we cited a number of concerns. Some updates:

Pensions/Other Post-Employment Benefits (OPEBs)
The Town remains on track to fully fund the Pension Fund by 2030 at which point the funding stream can be diverted to cover the OPEB liability.

Financial Health
The Town has maintained its AAA bond rating, indicating that the rating agencies continue to trust our management of our finances. As discussed, the Town has adjusted its approach to reserves, now endeavoring to set aside 10% of the prior year's net operating revenue. This has been easily achievable the past two budgets due to higher-than-expected Free Cash but may be a concern in the out years. As we continue to note, the Town has an inherent structural deficit: overall costs typically increase by 5% or more annually whereas revenue increases by 3-4% (largely held in check due to Proposition 2 1/2). As we note every year, there are three options:

- Increase the commercial tax base through new construction and new businesses
- Increase residential real estate taxes via overrides, continuing a trend we have employed for more than 20 years
- Cut or reallocate funding

It should be noted that the Select Board has appointed an Expenditures and Revenues Study Committee, charged with "determining what structural budget gap between Brookline's projected revenues and expenditures, if any, exists for FY2027 and beyond" and with making recommendations regarding possible efficiencies which can be achieved as well as with recommendations regarding a potential operating override for the May 2026 Town-wide election. We are happy that such a Committee exists; we caution that the closeness of the most recent debt exclusion vote shows that the appetite among the taxpayers to continue to increase the levy may be waning.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CAPITAL IMPROVEMENT PROGRAM

The Town's Capital Improvement Program (CIP) policies define a CIP Project as follows:

A capital improvement project is any project that improves or adds to the Town's infrastructure, has a substantial useful life, and costs $25,000 or more, regardless of the funding source. Examples of capital projects include the following:

- Construction of new buildings
- Major renovation of or additions to existing buildings
- Land acquisition or major land improvements
- Street reconstruction and resurfacing
- Sanitary sewer and storm drain construction and rehabilitation
- Water system construction and rehabilitation
- Major equipment acquisition and refurbishment
- Planning, feasibility studies, and design for potential capital projects

Criteria to evaluate CIP proposals include the following:

- Eliminates a proven or obvious hazard to public health and safety
- Required by legislation or action of other governmental jurisdictions
- Supports adopted plans, goals, objectives, and policies
- Reduces or stabilizes operating costs
- Prolongs the functional life of a capital asset of the Town by five years or more
- Replaces a clearly obsolete facility or maintains and makes better use of an existing facility
- Prevents a substantial reduction in an existing standard of service
- Directly benefits the Town's economic base by increasing property values
- Provides new programs having social, cultural, historic, environmental, economic, or aesthetic value
- Utilizes outside financing sources such as grants

For FY 2026, the Advisory Committee continued the practice it instituted in FY 2025 of reviewing each CIP item at the time departmental budgets are presented but waiting to vote the CIP in its entirety. In FY 2025 this resulted in the Committee making several reallocations among CIP requests as a result of both the review of items with full information and the consistent evaluation of individual CIP requests against stated CIP priorities.

In FY 2026, there was only one reallocation from the submitted requests: the $60,000 proposed to complete the design work for School Street Pedestrian/Bicycle Safety Lighting project has been incorporated into the Pierce School Project. As a result, the Street Rehab item was increased by $60,000. Despite the flexibility that budget votes provide, we do not believe that Capital funds should be arbitrarily moved between approved projects unless that was made explicit during departmental reviews — no matter how valuable, important, or visible the respective projects may be.

For FY 2026 the Committee's work was also informed by a 5 year look back at CIP funding allocations as well as the presentation and discussion of Warrant Article 10, the FY 2026 CPA allocations. In future years, the Committee would like to see the CPA allocations fully integrated into the CIP Plan.

The Committee wants to remind Town Meeting that the full CIP consists of projects funded by a variety of means, some of which are not appropriations controlled by Town Meeting. For FY 2026, State and Federal Grants account for 4% of the CIP appropriation funding. Funds requiring a Town Meeting vote include: Property Tax Revenues and Free Cash which provide the bulk of the funding (71%), while Utility Bonds (Water & Sewer projects) are 20% of the funding, and the remaining 5% are funded by General Fund Bonds (bonds supported by general tax revenues).

The Advisory Committee recommends funding the following FY 2026 CIP requests.

37. TOWN BUILDING REHABILITATION

Recommendation: $350,000 (Revenue Financed)

This is an on-going town-wide program for the repair and upgrade of Town facilities in between major renovation projects. Items funded under this program include large scale painting programs, new flooring, ceilings, window treatments and toilet upgrades. This program avoids more expensive rehabilitation that would be necessary if these items were left to deteriorate. In FY 2026 this program will address the common areas of the Public Health Building among other items.

38. COMPREHENSIVE PLAN

Recommendation: $182,200 (Revenue Financed)

In late 2023, the Planning Process Study Committee finished their work with the Planning Department to develop a work program, budget, and scope for an inclusive, community-driven planning and zoning reform process. Subsequently, the Town selected a consultant, Agency Landscape + Planning; their work will be guided by a 12-person Comprehensive Plan Steering Committee appointed by the Select Board, and by town staff.
The last Brookline Comprehensive Plan (PDF) was published in 2005. Although not required by state law, it serves as a guiding tool for actions of the town as well as the town's official comprehensive, or master, plan under Massachusetts General Laws chapter 41, section 81D.

This is the second and final year of funding for this item. In FY 2025 there was a $400,000 appropriation.

39. FIRE APPARATUS REHAB

Recommendation: $375,000 (Revenue Financed)

The Town's policy is to replace front-line fire engines every 17 years and front-line ladder trucks every 20 years. While this replacement schedule serves the Town very well, funding needs to be
appropriated every 10 years to rehab engines and every 12 years to rehab ladder trucks. Engine #5 is due for rehabilitation in FY2026 at an estimated cost of $375,000.

40. TRAFFIC CALMING

Recommendation: $350,000 (Revenue Financed)

The Town of Brookline's Traffic Calming Program is intended to implement safety improvements on residential streets, enhancing the safety and improving the quality of life of residents. The objectives of Roadway Safety & Traffic Calming projects, implemented by the Transportation Board and Department of Public Works include:

- Encouraging citizen involvement in all phases of neighborhood traffic management;
- Influencing driver behavior through education and design;
- Ensuring that limited Town resources are utilized in a cost-effective and efficient manner;
- Implementing traffic calming techniques that are both effective and compatible with the character of the affected neighborhoods and improve public safety without jeopardizing emergency response needs, creating hazards, or reducing mobility;
- Improving the livability and safety of Brookline neighborhoods by mitigating the impact of traffic and promoting safer conditions for residents, motorists, bicyclists, and pedestrians; and
- Installing traffic calming measures on streets where their implementation will reduce traffic speeds and/or improve the safety of movements by pedestrians and bicyclists

FY2026 CIP funds would be utilized to advance final design and construction of a group of approved traffic calming / safety improvement projects.

41. VISION ZERO ACTION PLAN PRIORITY SEGMENTS
Recommendation - $500,000 (Revenue Financed)
Brookline's Vision Zero Action Plan establishes the Town's strategy for reaching zero injuries and fatalities on our streets. The plan will also make the Town eligible for federal grant funding to support this work.

The planning process is guided by the Brookline Vision Zero Committee, appointed by the Select Board. Four of the seven members represent the Transportation Boards, the Pedestrian Advisory Committee, the Bicycle Advisory Committee, and the Safe Routes to Schools Task Force, while the other three members consist of two at-large and a Select Board representative.

The FY 2026 funding will be used to make safety improvement to a plan identified High Priority Network. The work will include curb extensions and daylighting crosswalks, bicycle conflict markings, enhanced crosswalk signage and Rectangular Rapid Flashing Beacons (RRFBs). Where feasible, work will include road diets and the addition of vertical separation for existing bike lanes.

42. BICYCLE ACCESS IMPROVEMENTS
Recommendation - $450,000 (Revenue Financed)
Projects supported through CIP funds usually originate from the Green Routes Bicycle Network Plan developed by the Bicycle Advisory Committee. The Plan identifies a network of streets for prioritizing bicycling improvements. FY 26 funds will be used for the design phase of bicycle improvements for Park Street (($200,000) and for the design and implementation of safe bicycle routes from South Brookline to Brookline High School $250,000).

43. PARKING METER REPLACEMENT
Recommendation - $465,000 (Revenue Financed)
The Town of Brookline has 30 multi-space meters and approximately 1800 single-space parking meters. The Town first began installing smart IPS meters in 2012. Those first meters

are now approaching the end of their operational life and are in need of replacement or significant upgrades. Repair parts and tech support for the Town's older models of both multi-space and single-space are being phased out. The typical life expectancy of a parking meter is 10 years. The first priority for replacement is the multi-space meters as they are no longer supported, followed by the replacement of single space meters. The program will continue as funding becomes available.

44. STREET REHABILITATION — TOWN

Recommendation - $ 5,190,000 (Revenue Financed)

The Department of Public Works, in collaboration with Apex Companies, has established a Pavement Maintenance and Preservation Program (PMPP) to maintain the Town's roads efficiently and effectively. The PMPP is developed using road condition and road use information, enabling the selection of the most appropriate and cost-effective techniques to improve roadway conditions and extend pavement life. The development of a Pavement Condition Indexes (PCI) to systematically assess and quantify the condition of roadways allows data-driven maintenance and investment decisions. PCI's intended goal is to prioritize repairs, optimize budgets, and extend pavement lifespan while improving safety and mobility.

The Town maintains nearly 100 miles of roadway. The approach to repairs and maintenance is balanced between repairing infrastructure in poor condition and maintaining infrastructure in good condition. Currently, nearly 40 miles of roadway are in need of rehabilitation, while 55 miles fall into the maintenance categories. The cost of addressing the backlog to perform all maintenance and rehabilitation work is about $135 million.

The PCI rating that measures the condition of the roads has fallen from 71.62 in 2020, to 68.15 in 2023. As the number declines, costs for road repair rise, both because of construction inflation and the increased deteriorated condition of the road. To maintain the current PCI rating of 68.15, would cost about $5 million per year. To raise the PCI to 70 would cost $8.4 million.

The issue of the deteriorating state of the roads was noted during public comment. The Town faces the choice between continued deterioration and finding increased funding for road maintenance and repair.

Going forward, Street Rehabilitation projects will be also be looked at through the lens of Complete Streets and will include traffic volume data, traffic counts, vehicular speed, crash summaries, pedestrian reports, sidewalk conditions, the Green Routes Master Plan for bicycle access, Safe Routes to School, traffic signals, accessibility ramps, and traffic calming. This is a far more comprehensive approach than has been used in the past and will involve more process and greater community input. It is also an approach that will cost more in time and in dollars and presents even greater justification for significantly increasing the annual appropriations for the Street Rehabilitation Program.

45. SIDEWALK REPAIR

Recommendation - $750,000 (Revenue Financed)

Sidewalk Repair funds are directed to sidewalks that are not reconstructed as part of a larger street rehabilitation or major repair project. The 2008 Override included $50,000 for sidewalk repair, to be increased annually by 2.5%. Small sections of sidewalks are repaired by the crews of the Highway Division of the DPW, and some of the CIP appropriation is used to purchase materials for this purpose. Most of the CIP funds, however, are used to pay outside contractors to repair long stretches of sidewalks in the Town.
Similar to the department's pavement management program, the DPW Sidewalk Improvement program uses a data-driven approach to repair deteriorated sidewalks and ramps, achieve Town-wide ADA/AAB compliance, provide essential pedestrian connectivity, and create more walkable neighborhoods. While some sidewalks are reconstructed as part of the street reconstruction program, those that are not are funded under this program.

46. DPW FLEET LATERAL PROTECTIVE DEVICES

Recommendation - $280,000 (Revenue Financed)

These devices prevent a pedestrian or cyclist from falling under a truck in the event of a collision. The State has mandated that safety features be added to municipal trucks and those trucks owned by municipal contractors. DPW will be retrofitting vehicles purchased in 2021- 2024 with a gross weight of 10,001 lbs or more.

47. DPW FACILITIES FEASIBILITY STUDY

Recommendation - $250,000 (Revenue Financed)

DPW operates the following facilities:
The Transfer Station, Larz Anderson Park Maintenance Yard, Water and Sewer Garage, and the Municipal Service Center.

The feasibility study aims to evaluate all of the DPW facilities, identify deficiencies, and develop a long-term plan to invest in the assets, efficiency, services, and emergency response facilities and functions that the Town of Brookline will require both now and in the future.

48. WASHINGTON ST. REHAB AND COMPLETE STREETS

Recommendation - $800,000 (Revenue Financed)

The primary goal of this project is to rehabilitate an arterial roadway that is in poor condition and to create a true Complete Street throughout the Washington Street corridor. Work will take place on 1.3 miles of the street and associated intersections from Station Street in Brookline Village northerly up to and including its intersection with Beacon Street in Washington Square,

Construction work is targeted for FY 28 and FY 29; the current estimated cost is $29 million. Of that amount, 80% will be federally funded and 20% will be state funded. The allocation of CIP funds, which began several years ago, covers preliminary design, community engagement, right of way agreements, engineering bid documents, construction oversight, project management, funding assistance, implementation, and Town preferred betterments.

The project will reconstruct sidewalks along both sides of the entire corridor and will provide protected bicycle facilities in both directions that are separated from vehicular traffic for a vast majority of the corridor. Other multimodal improvements include the provision of dedicated bus pull-out space outside of the travel lanes as space permits. The project will replace the existing signals along Washington Street's length and will include such streetscape enhancements as new lighting, benches, and trees.

Although the section of Washington Street from Beacon Street to the city line is not part of this project, it will be put out to bid separately and managed by the Town and its contractor.

49. BIG BELLY COMPACTING WASTE STATIONS
Recommendation - $145,000 (Revenue Financed)
An increase in food consumption taking place in the outdoor spaces found in commercial areas, parks, school grounds, and playgrounds, has led to an increase in the rodent population. Addressing this problem requires a multi-pronged approach, including reducing the number of open top trash receptacles in public areas as well as replacing trash compacting dumpsters on town and school grounds.
Big Belly waste stations are currently the best waste management product on the market for both effectively collecting and compacting a high volume of waste, as well as remaining rodent-proof due to their specific design. In order to phase out open-top trash receptacles and reduce the amount of overflowing trash receptacles, DPW plans to add ten to twelve new Big Belly trash and recycling units throughout Brookline's public spaces on an annual basis. Currently, the town has 20 trash compacting dumpsters on town and school grounds with a life expectancy of 8 - 10 years. Over time, the bottom of the dumpsters rot and subsequently require replacement. This funding will allow the replacement of four dumpsters per year for the next four years.

50. GRIGGS PARK
Recommendation - $2,100,000 (Revenue Financed)
Griggs Park is located on a former wetland, in an enclave surrounded by houses and apartment buildings between Washington and Beacon Streets. As climate change brings heavier and more frequent storms to the region, former wetland sites, such as this one, will require additional investment in green infrastructure to keep them functioning and flourishing.
Current features of Griggs Park include a circular pathway around a collection of trees and vegetation; an open lawn area, seating and picnic areas; a basketball area; and a playground. The playground was last renovated in 1997 and is overdue for a complete renovation. The design was funded in FY 2025. The recommended funds are for construction.

51. PARKS AND PLAYGROUNDS REHABILITATION & UPGRADE

Recommendation - $310,000 (Revenue Financed)

This annual, town-wide program directs CIP funds to the evaluation, repair and replacement of unsafe and deteriorating park, playground, fence, and field facilities or components. Items funded under this program include fences, gates, backstops, retaining walls, picnic furniture, turf restoration, infield refurbishment, bench replacements, play structures, safety surfacing, and drainage improvements. This program avoids more expensive rehabilitation that would be necessary if these items were left to deteriorate.

52. TOWN/SCHOOL GROUNDS REHAB

Recommendation - $185,000 (Revenue Financed)

Town and School grounds require on-going structural improvements and repair. These funds will be applied to create attractive and functional landscapes and hardscape improvements including plant installation, regrading, reseeding, tree work, repair to concrete or asphalt walkways through the site, trash receptacles, bike racks, drainage improvements, retaining walls, and repairs to stairs, treads, railings, benches, or other exterior structures. This funding does not include capital replacement of areas over building structures or directly connected to the buildings, such as entrance stairways and ramps into the building that are under the Building Department's jurisdiction. This program avoids more expensive rehabilitation that would be necessary if these items were left to deteriorate.

53. TENNIS COURTS/BASKETBALL COURTS

Recommendation - $200,000 (Revenue Financed)

Given that Community Preservation Act funds have been sought for renovation of the tennis courts at the Ridley School and the Coolidge Playground, the CIP funds are expected to be expended on improvements to the tennis courts at Waldstein (Dean) Park .

54. COMFORT STATIONS

Recommendation - $25,000 (Revenue Financed)

DPW's Parks and Open Space Division manages eight public restroom facilities. CIP funds are used for improvements to these facilities such as structural upgrades, new doors, ventilation and flooring improvements, toilets, sinks, fixtures, lighting, utilities, and drainage.

55. TREE REMOVAL AND REPLACEMENT / URBAN FORESTRY MANAGEMENT

Recommendation - $375,000 (Revenue Financed)

The tree removal and replacement program is the Town's effort to balance street tree removals with plantings. As trees mature or are impacted by storm damage or disease, it is critical to remove these before they become public safety hazards. New tree plantings are also critical, as they directly impact the tree-lined character of the community, improve stormwater quality, provide oxygen, reduce heat impact in the summer, and improve the overall quality of life in Brookline. In addition, funding is included for on-going management work in the four conservation properties (Hall's Pond Sanctuary, Amory Woods Sanctuary, D. Blakely Hoar Sanctuary, and the Lost Pond Sanctuary) and parks. Storm damage, disease, and old age continue to reduce tree canopies. The funds will be utilized to remove hazard trees and provide structural, health, and safety pruning to prolong the life and viability of significant trees. New trees will be planted in anticipation of the ultimate loss of existing mature trees.

Included in the requested annual amount is funding for Urban Forest Management to address a range of significant improvements needed, such as tree removals, crown thinning, soil amendments, woodland canopy gap management, invasive removal, pest management, health and structural pruning, and planting throughout the Town's parks and open spaces. This program will help with resiliency to disease, pests and rapid decline attributed with trees unmanaged in an urban environment.

56. WALNUT HILLS CEMETERY
Recommendation - $100,000 (Revenue Financed)
In the coming fiscal year CIP funds will be combined with Cemetery Perpetual Care funds for roadway and drainage improvements in the Walnut Hills Cemetery.

57. ELIOT RECREATION CENTER IMPROVEMENTS
Recommendation - $800,000 (Revenue Financed)
The Eliot Recreation Center, located at 133 Eliot Street, serves as the primary administrative hub for the Recreation Department and houses 12 full-time employees. Additionally, the building includes a fully furnished classroom on the ground level that hosts the Town's after school program, directly serving Brookline Public School students.

The building is significantly aged, with much of the equipment and interior finishes original to the department's occupancy that began in 2002. After more than 20 years of continuous operations, the facility is showing considerable wear. The planned improvements include: replacement of carpeting, painting and upgrading of staff workstations, IT infrastructure improvements, renovation and expansion of conference room, the addition of a restroom to support the ground floor classroom, and improvements to the public restroom which supports Warren Field Park.

58. SCHOOL FURNITURE
Recommendation - $75,000 (Revenue Financed)
Funds in this program have always been earmarked for the replacement of school furniture, which absorbs significant wear and tear through daily use, and to respond to the occasional special requests from a PSB teacher. In FY 2025 funds were utilized for many purposes beyond this designation, including items which do not qualify as Capital Improvements. Though no changes were made to the FY 2026 allocation, the language of appropriation has been clarified to limit the use of funds to "furniture exclusively for educational and administrative uses."

59. HVAC EQUIPMENT
Recommendation - $595,000 (Revenue Financed)
These funds would be used to primarily replace the larger, more expensive parts up to and including the entire unit for air conditioners, HVAC equipment and boilers. A majority of the money will be used for air conditioner compressor replacements. There are presently 199 permanent air conditioning systems in both Town and School buildings. Their sizes range from 2 tons to over 100 tons. The equipment age dates from 1975 to 2017, with 112 units

being 10 years or older. Typically, air conditioning compressors last only 5 - 10 years. Depending on the size, costs can range from $3,500 to $150,000. Instead of being proactive, there is presently a reactive response when there is a failure, usually in very hot weather. The cost to repair is born out of the operations and maintenance budget (O&M). However, with the large increase in installations of AC equipment over the years, the O&M would not be able to handle a large cost such as this. The plan would be to replace compressors and do upgrades in the off season, based on age and conditions.

The monies would also be used to replace gas fire equipment with no fossil fuel equipment in all buildings which would include hot water and heat. This would be a step forward in achieving zero emissions by 2050. Emissions would be reduced over a number of years. The first step would be to replace gas-fired hot water heaters with hybrid electric hot water heaters. Heat pump units would subsequently be phased in.

60. UNDERGROUND TANK REMOVAL

Recommendation - $135,000 (Revenue Financed)

These funds would be used to remove underground fuel oil tanks, some almost 25 years old. The tanks came with a 30 warranty. There are 26 tanks at various school and town sites. New tanks would be installed inside of the buildings (1000 gallon or less) to replace larger (5000-15000 gallon) tanks. Also small, typically 275 gallon, tanks would be replaced with new tanks of the same size. The boilers are set up for dual fuel. There is no reason to remove and replace the boilers or burners as they function well. By installing a small, above ground tank inside, we can have the backup function of using oil to heat the buildings in case of an emergency or gas shortage.

Some funding may come from the UST state fund. It is estimated that 50% of the costs would be reimbursed for the tank removals. Typical costs for tank removals would be in the $50,000 range. If the tank leaks, the costs could be up to 10 times this amount.

61. TOWN/SCHOOL BUILDING — ADA RENOVATIONS

Recommendation - $95,000 (Revenue Financed)

This annual program of improvements is requested so that Town and School buildings can be brought into compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), which requires that the Town make public buildings accessible to all.

Handicap operators, signage, chair lifts, automatic flushometers are all eligible for these funds Some of these items are on a maintenance cycle. Others are in new locations or in addition to current ones. Some of these funds are also used for reasonable accommodations for HR or student requirements.

62. TOWN/SCHOOL BUILDING - ELEVATOR RENOVATIONS

Recommendation - $1,150,000 (Revenue Financed)

The Town presently has 47 elevators, LULA (Limited Use/Limited Application) elevators, and wheelchair lifts throughout all buildings. When a building is renovated, most elevators are upgraded (new controls, motors, cables, refurbishment of the car, etc.). Some elevators are also partially upgraded to meet the requirements of the existing building codes. The buildings that have not been renovated have elevators that are close to 30 years old. Maintenance is an issue and parts are increasingly difficult to find.

Renovation/upgrades of existing lifts and elevators occurs at the rate of 1 to 2 per year. Extra funds are being put into this category in FY26 with the expectation that funds will not be needed in out years. Work in all of the schools is projected to be finished all of the schools in FY 2049

63. TOWN/SCHOOL BUILDING - ENERGY CONSERVATION

Recommendation - $225,000 (Revenue Financed)

Investments are needed to decrease energy consumption in Town and School buildings. Programs include, but are not limited to, lighting retrofit and controls, energy efficient motors, insulation, and heating and cooling equipment. In addition, water conservation efforts are explored. This program augments existing gas and electric utility conservation programs along with Green Communities Grant Funding. A continued area of focus is building commissioning. Many years ago, a building's HVAC system was set up by multiple contractors and then signed off by the design engineer. Sometimes there would be control issues, leading to complaints or high energy usage. The Building Department, for all new projects, hires a Commissioning Agent. Recommissioning of certain buildings is suggested in order to confirm that the equipment was designed, installed and set up properly. Another investment has been with variable frequency drives (VFDs). These VFDs control the speed of motors for pumps and fans. They slow the motor down using inputs from the energy management system based on the needs of the space.

64. TOWN/SCHOOL BUILDING - ENERGY MANAGEMENT SYSTEM

Recommendation - $220,000 (Revenue Financed)

This program upgrades the energy management systems in Town and School buildings. A few of the larger buildings have older (30 years) energy management systems that have exceeded their life expectancy and replacement parts are no longer available. These systems would be replaced and upgraded with new web-based systems integrated into the Town's existing computer network. Other systems would be upgraded with newer software or firmware. The Building Department will continue to work with the Information Technology Department on these projects. Hardware lifecycle is 10 years, while software upgrades are needed every 3 years. As buildings get more complicated, this cost may go up in the future.

65. TOWN/SCHOOL BUILDING - ENVELOPE/FENESTRATION
Recommendation - $900,000 (Revenue Financed)
The outside envelope of facilities includes masonry, bricks and mortar, flashing, dental work, coping stones, metal shelves, and tower work. Some of these structures are over 100+ years old and have never had exterior work done to them. A number of buildings have windows, door entrances, and other wall openings (fenestration) that are in need of repair/replacement. Some have wood components (clapboard, window trim) that fail and need replacement or resurfacing (painting, cover with metal) Failure of the material **allows** water to penetrate into buildings behind walls and ceilings, causing security and safety problems. This program includes all masonry work and repairs to the building and its equipment resulting from envelope failures as well as testing, inspections, and upgrades or any associated services or components.

The first 20-year envelope plan has just been completed. In FY 2026 new priorities and a plan will be developed.

66. PUBLIC BUILDING FIRE ALARM UPGRADES
Recommendation - $175,000 (Revenue Financed)
The Building Department has just completed a 10-year plan and is commencing a new plan. The fire alarms are essentially computer systems which require periodic upgrading and replacement.

67. TOWN/SCHOOL BUILDING - SECURITY/LIFE SAFETY SYSTEMS
Recommendation - $860,000 (Revenue Financed)
Over the last number of years, several large capital projects have been undertaken that included security improvements in Town and School buildings. This program will extend the effort and improve areas where security may be lacking. In general, the plan calls for making all doors around the perimeter of a building more secure by replacing the doors, frames, door handles, and locks with electronic locks that may only be opened with a keypad and/or on a specific schedule. Only the front main entrance of the building would allow for general access. At the front door, a speaker and doorbell will be added to connect to the building's existing intercom or phone system for use by visitors. The lighting around each building will be improved and placed on a timer. A small camera system connected to a computer will be added at the main entrance to monitor access to the building.

These funds are also used to continue the on-going process of replacement and installation of new and upgraded burglar alarms, fire alarm systems, sprinkler systems, emergency lighting, and egress signs.
In FY 26 funds will be used to replace a mobile emergency generator which was originally donated by the MWRA 20 years ago. The emergency generator will be large enough to power essential services at the four Town designated emergency shelters: Brookline High School, the Baker School, the New Lincoln School and the Lawrence School.

68. CLASSROOM CAPACITY
Recommendation - $761,948 (Revenue Financed)
The Classroom Capacity account was first funded to address ongoing space needs for students and staff within the existing eight elementary schools. Classroom Capacity CIP funds are now used for leased space. The Advisory Committee continues to be concerned that these leases are inappropriately placed in the CIP and should instead be funded from the PSB Operating Budget.

In FY 2026 there are two leases remaining for the Brookline Early Education Program (BEEP): one for Temple Ohabei Shalom and the other for Temple Emeth. Both leases are renewable for one-year terms at the option of the Public Schools of Brookline and the Select Board, with written notice of the renewal provided by December 31 (Temple Ohabei Shalom) or November 30 (Temple Emeth) of the preceding year.

The Temple Ohabei Shalom lease includes approximately 6,800 square feet of space that is shared with the Temple's own after school care program which limits BEEP's use. The location houses five classrooms, two small offices, and a conference room. The current plan is to continue the lease until completion of the new Pierce (FY28 target). The options years expire in FY30.

The Temple Emeth lease includes full-day access to approximately 9,800 square feet of space. Currently, four BEEP classrooms are housed at this location. The original lease term was ten years with one-year tenant extension options beginning in FY24. and expiring in FY29.

The Advisory Committee continues to be troubled that relocating the BEEP classrooms to the Baldwin School was not considered before the PSB re-directed CIP funds allocated for other purposes for the conversion of the Baldwin School into office space.

69. STORMWATER IMPROVEMENTS
Recommendation $500,000 (Utility Bond)
The Town is actively developing plans and implementing procedures to prepare for and adapt to changes in the weather. This includes monitoring and assessing locations that are flood-prone to develop ways to mitigate and/or reduce the potential for storm damage by managing stormwater flows upstream of these sensitive areas. Project funding will also be put towards consulting services and construction projects to comply with the Environmental Protection Agency's National Pollutant Discharge Elimination System Phase II Municipal Separate Storm Sewer System Permit.

There will also be a focus on Illicit Discharge and Detection work to reduce bacterial contamination discharged from the Town's drainage system. Projects will be prioritized in environmental justice areas within the Town or in climate-vulnerable neighborhoods and will support goals of both the Town's Climate Action Plan and Urban Forest Climate Resiliency Master Plan.

70. WATER SYSTEM IMPROVEMENTS
Recommendation $2,000,000 (Utility Bond)
Under the Federal Lead and Copper Rule Revisions (LCRR), all municipalities are required to complete a Lead Service Line (LSL) Inventory. The Town's inventory found no known lead service lines in the water system. However, the results indicated that out of the approximately 9,129 water service lines in Brookline, 108 did not list the material type, and are considered unknowns. Unknowns are assumed to be lead-containing and require further investigation or replacement. Lead goosenecks are not currently regulated but were used in the early 1900s to connect straight sections of iron service pipe to mains and to buildings, and contain lead. Identification and removal of these lead goosenecks are part of the program. FY26 funding will be used to replace any water system-related components and other water system improvements as required.

71. WASTE WATER SYSTEM IMPROVEMENTS
Recommendation - $3,000,000 (Utility Bond)
The Wastewater System Improvements project provides funding for the rehabilitation of the wastewater collection system (sanitary sewer). The asset rehabilitation program is based on the recommendations of the Sewer System Capital Improvement Program completed in 2016. The goal is to rehabilitate the entire sewer system over 18 years to protect the asset and reduce infiltration and inflow (I&I) by 2032. I&I reduction not only helps reduce the chance of backups in the system, but also lowers the MWRA wholesale costs by reducing extraneous clear water flows. Funding for this annual work is supported by generous grant/loan programs offered by the MWRA, reducing the Town's financial impact significantly.

72. TOWN SCHOOL ROOF REPAIR/REPLACEMENT PROGRAM
Recommendation - $1,400,000 (General Fund Bond Financed)
The Building Department tries to align the building envelope and roofing work to occur during the same years so as to limit the need to close an individual school for multiple summers. As with the Building Envelope and Elevator programs, the majority of work in this account is following a multi-year plan.

ADVISORY COMMITTEE'S FISCAL YEAR 2026 BUDGET RECOMMENDATION

By a vote of 15-0 with no abstentions, the Advisory Committee submits the FY2026 Town Budget with a recommendation of FAVORABLE ACTION on the following motion:

VOTED: To approve the budget for fiscal year 2026 set forth in the attached Tables I and II; to appropriate the amounts set forth for such fiscal year in the departments and expenditure object classifications within departments, as set forth in Tables I and II, subject to the following conditions; to raise all sums so appropriated, unless other funding is provided herein; and to establish the following authorizations:

1.) <u>TRANSFERS AMONG APPROPRIATIONS</u>: Transfers between the total departmental appropriations separately set forth in Tables 1 and 2 shall be permitted by vote of Town Meeting or as otherwise provided by Massachusetts General Laws Chapter 44, Section 33B(b). Within each separate departmental appropriation, expenditures shall be restricted to the expenditure object classifications set forth in the recommendation of the Advisory Committee, and voted by the Town Meeting, for each department, subject to the following exceptions:

A) Expenditures within the appropriation for the School Department shall not be restricted.

B) The following transfers within the appropriations for each department (other than the School Department and the Library Department), shall be permitted only with the prior written approval of the Select Board and Advisory Committee:

i) Transfers from the appropriation for the capital outlay object classification to any other object classification.

ii) Transfers to the appropriation for the personal services object classification from any other object classification.

iii) Any transfer which has the effect of increasing the number of positions or the compensation for any position, exclusive of adjustments in wages and benefits voted separately by Town Meeting.

v) Transfers within the Department of Public Works from the Parks Division to any other purpose.

vi) Transfers within the Department of Public Works from the Snow and Ice budget to any other purpose.

C) Transfers within the Library Department appropriation shall be permitted with the approval of the Board of Library Trustees, and written notice of such approval shall be submitted promptly to the Advisory Committee, Town Administrator and Town Comptroller.

D) All other transfers within the total appropriation for a particular department shall be permitted with the written approval of the Town Administrator, subject to review and approval of the Select Board, and upon the condition that written notice of each such approval shall be submitted promptly to the Advisory Committee and Town Comptroller.

2.) <u>PROCUREMENT CONTRACTS AND LEASES</u>: The Chief Procurement Officer is authorized to lease, or lease with an option to purchase, any equipment or capital item funded within the FY2026 budget, and to solicit and award contracts for terms of not more than four years, provided that in each instance the longer term is determined to be in the best interest of the Town by a vote of the Select Board.

3.) ALLOCATION OF SALARY ADJUSTMENTS: Appropriations for salary and wage adjustments (Item #20) shall be transferred by the Town Comptroller to the various affected departments within (60) days from the beginning of the fiscal year, or in the absence of duly approved collective bargaining agreements, within (60) days of the approval of the collective bargaining agreements by Town Meeting. The Select Board shall determine the salaries, which may include merit adjustments, for employees not included in any collective bargaining agreement.

Should a balance remain after the Town Comptroller has made the transfers specified herein, said balance shall be transferred by the Town Comptroller to a budget line entitled Personnel Services Reserve (Item #19), which shall be used to fund costs incurred over the course of the fiscal year pursuant to employee contracts and/or established personnel policies. The Town Comptroller shall include an accounting of all transfers made from this reserve in the Annual Financial Report.

4.) STIPENDS / SALARIES OF ELECTED OFFICIALS: The stipends of members of the Select Board shall be at the rate of $4,500 per year for the Chair and at the rate of $3,500 per year for each of the other four members. The annual salary of the Town Clerk shall be at the rate of $120,563 effective July 1, 2025, plus any adjustment approved by vote of the Select Board. The Town Clerk shall pay all fees received by the Town Clerk by virtue of their office into the Town treasury for Town use.

5.) VACANT POSITIONS: No appropriation for salaries, wages, or other compensation shall be expended for any benefit-eligible position which has become vacant during the fiscal year unless the Select Board, at an official meeting, has determined that the filling of the vacancy is either essential to the proper operation of the Town or is required by law. This condition shall not apply to appropriations of the School Department.

6.) GOLF ENTERPRISE FUND: The following sums, totaling $3,034,459 shall be appropriated into the Golf Enterprise Fund, and may be expended under the direction of the Park and Recreation Commission, for the operation of the Golf Course:

Salaries	$985,759
Purchase of Services	$446,535
Supplies	$508,047
Other	$10,600
Utilities	$145,595
Capital	$405,500
Debt Service	$210,000
Reserve	$25,000
Total Appropriations	$2,737,036
Indirect Costs	$297,423
Total Costs	$3,034,459

Total costs of 3,034,459 to be funded from golf receipts with $297,423 to be reimbursed to the General Fund for indirect costs.

7.) <u>WATER AND SEWER ENTERPRISE FUND</u>: The following sums, totaling $34,479,954 shall be appropriated into the Water and Sewer Enterprise Fund, and may be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works for the Water and Sewer purposes as voted below:

	Water	Sewer	Total
Salaries	2,992,742	586,853	3,579,595
Purchase of Services	296,025	262,500	558,525
Supplies	173,500	32,000	205,500
Other	19,000	7,550	26,550
Utilities	126,709	-	126,709
Capital	853,623	80,000	933,623
Intergovernmental	9,027,083	14,169,817	23,196,900
Debt Service	1,092,250	1,417,779	2,510,029
Reserve	147,631	191,413	339,044
Total Appropriations	14,728,563	16,747,912	31,476,475
Indirect Costs	2,356,360	647,119	3,003,479
Total Costs	17,084,923	17,395,031	34,479,954

Total costs of $34,479,954 to be funded from water and sewer receipts with $3,003,954 to be reimbursed to the General Fund for indirect costs.

8.) <u>REVOLVING FUNDS:</u>

a.) The Park and Recreation Commission is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for special recreation programs and events. All receipts from said programs and events shall be credited to the fund. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $5,200,000.

b.) The Building Commissioner is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for the repair and maintenance of the Town's rental properties, including all those listed in the vote under Article 13 of the Warrant for the 1999 Annual Town Meeting. All receipts from said rental properties shall be credited to the fund. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $225,000.

c.) The Commissioner of Public Works is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for the construction and reconstruction, upkeep, maintenance, repair and improvement of sidewalks and walkways along public streets and ways over, across and through town owned property. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $100,000.

d.) The Director of Planning and Community Development is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for the Façade Improvement Loan Program. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $30,000.

e.) The Library Director is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for the Copier Program. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $30,000.

f.) The School Department is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for the School bus Program. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $75,000.

g.) The Commissioner of Public Works is authorized to maintain and operate, under the provisions of General Laws Chapter 44, Section 53E1/2 and Chapter 79 of the Acts of 2005, a revolving fund for the Electric Vehicle Charging Station program. Annual expenditures from the fund shall not exceed $330,000

9.) <u>SCHOOLHOUSE MAINTENANCE AND REPAIR</u>: The sum of $8,630,428 included within the Building Department appropriation for school building maintenance, shall be expended for School Plant repair and maintenance and not for any other purpose. The listing of work to be accomplished shall be established by the School Department. The feasibility and prioritization of the work to be accomplished under the school plant repair and maintenance budget shall be determined by the Superintendent of Schools and the Building Commissioner, or their designees.

10.) <u>SNOW AND ICE BUDGET</u>: The sum of $450,205, included within the Department of Public Works appropriation for snow and ice operations, shall be expended for snow and ice operations and not for any other purpose, unless transferred per the provisions of Section 1.B.vi of this Article 9.

11.) <u>INTERFUND TRANSFERS</u>: In order to fund the appropriations voted for the various departments itemized on Table 1, the Town Comptroller is authorized to make the following interfund transfers:

Cemetery Sales Special Revenue Fund [to the General Fund for the Department of Public Works]	$ 100,000
Recreation Revolving Fund [to the General Fund for benefits reimbursement]	$576,575

12.) <u>HOST COMMUNITY/OPIOID FUNDS</u>

Appropriate $671,021 to be expended under the direction of the Town Administrator for marijuana and opioid mitigation activities, and to meet the appropriation transfer $343,074 from the HCA stabilization fund and $327,947 from the Opioid stabilization fund.

13.) <u>BUDGETARY REPORTING</u>: The Town Comptroller shall provide the Advisory Committee with a report on the budgetary condition of the Town as of September 30, December 31, March 31, and June 30, within 45 days of said dates. This financial report shall include a summary of the status of all annual and special appropriations voted in this article; a report on the status of all special appropriations voted in prior years which remain open at the reporting date; and a summary of the status of all revenues and inter-fund transfers which have been estimated to finance the appropriations voted under this article.

14.) <u>SPECIAL APPROPRIATIONS</u>: The appropriations set forth as items 37 through 77, inclusive, in Table 1 shall be specially appropriated for the following purposes. In addition, with the exception of Items #69 - 72, they shall be transferred from the General Fund to the Revenue-Financed Capital Fund.

Appropriate sums of money for the following special purposes:

37.) Raise and appropriate $350,000 to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the rehabilitation of Town buildings.

38.) Raise and appropriate $182,200, to be expended under the direction of the Director of Planning and Community Development, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the purpose of completing the Town's Comprehensive Plan.

39.) Raise and appropriate $375,000, to be expended under the direction of the Fire Chief, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the rehabilitation of Engine #5.

40.) Raise and appropriate $350,000, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, for traffic calming.

41.) Raise and appropriate $500,000, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, for the Vision Zero Action Plan Priority Segments Design & Implementation.

42.) Raise and appropriate $450,000, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, for bike access improvements.

43.) Raise and appropriate $465,000, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, for the parking meter replacement program.

44.) Raise and appropriate $5,190,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the rehabilitation of streets.

45.) Raise and appropriate $750,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the rehabilitation of sidewalks.

46.) Raise and appropriate $280,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the Department of Public Works fleet lateral protective devices.

47.) Raise and appropriate $250,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for a Department of Public Works facilities study.

48.) Raise and appropriate $800,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for design work related to the Washington Street Rehabilitation and Complete Streets Program.

49.) Raise and appropriate $145,000, or any other sum, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, Big Belly compacting waste stations.

50.) Raise and appropriate $2,100,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the renovation of Griggs Park

51.) Raise and appropriate $310,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for the renovation of playground equipment, fields, and fencing.

52.) Raise and appropriate $185,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works for the rehabilitation of Town and School grounds.

53.) Raise and appropriate $200,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board and the Park and Recreation Commission, for the rehabilitation of tennis courts and basketball courts.

54.) Raise and appropriate $25,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, for improvements to comfort stations.

55.) Raise and appropriate $375,000, or any other sum, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board and the Tree Planting Committee, for the removal and replacement of trees.

56.) Raise and appropriate $100,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, for improvements to the Walnut Hills Cemetery.

57.) Raise and appropriate $800,000, to be expended under the direction of the Recreation Director, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board and the Park and Recreation Commission, for Eliot Recreation Center Improvements.

58.) Raise and appropriate $75,000, to be expended under the direction of the Chief Procurement Officer exclusively for educational and administrative furniture upgrades.

59.) Raise and appropriate $595,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner for HVAC equipment.

60.) Raise and appropriate $135,000, be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner for underground tank removal.

61.) Raise and appropriate $95,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner for ADA renovations to Town and School facilities.

62.) Raise and appropriate $1,150,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner for elevator renovations.

63.) Raise and appropriate $225,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner for upgrades to energy conservation projects in Town and School facilities.

64.) Raise and appropriate $220,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner for upgrades to energy management systems in Town and School facilities.

65.) Raise and appropriate $900,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commission, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board and, with respect to School Buildings, by the School Committee, for building envelope / fenestration repairs to Town and School facilities.

66.) Raise and appropriate $175,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner, for public building fire alarm upgrades.

67.) Raise and appropriate $860,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commissioner, for improvements to life safety systems and building security in Town and School facilities.

68.) Raise and appropriate $761,948, to be expended under the direction of the School Superintendent, with any necessary contracts to be approved by the School Committee, for the expansion of classroom capacity in various schools.

69.) Raise and appropriate $500,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for storm water improvements and to meet the appropriation, authorize the Treasurer, with the approval of the Select Board, to borrow $500,000 under General Laws, Chapter 44, Section 7 (1), as amended, or pursuant to any other enabling authority; and authorize the Select Board to apply for, accept, receive and expend grants, aid, reimbursements, loans, and all other forms of funding and financial assistance from both state and federal sources and agencies for such purpose.

70.) Raise and appropriate $2,000,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for water system improvements and to meet the appropriation, authorize the Treasurer, with the approval of the Select Board, to borrow $2,000,000 under General Laws, Chapter 44, Section 8(5), as amended, or pursuant to any other enabling authority; and authorize the Select Board to apply for, accept, receive and expend grants, aid, reimbursements, loans, and all other forms of funding and financial assistance from both state and federal sources and agencies for such purpose.

71.) Raise and appropriate $3,000,000, to be expended under the direction of the Commissioner of Public Works, with any necessary contracts over $100,000 to be approved by the Select Board, for wastewater system improvements and to meet the appropriation, authorize the Treasurer, with the approval of the Select Board, to borrow $3,000,000 under General Laws, Chapter 44, Section 7(1), as amended, or pursuant to any other enabling authority; and authorize the Select Board to apply for, accept, receive and expend grants, aid, reimbursements, loans, and all other forms of funding and financial assistance from both state and federal sources and agencies for such purpose.

72.) Raise and appropriate $1,400,000, to be expended under the direction of the Building Commission, with any necessary contracts to be approved by the Select Board and, with respect to School Buildings, by the School Committee, for roof repairs to Town and School facilities and to meet the appropriation, authorize the Treasurer with the approval of the Select Board, to borrow $1,400,000 under General Law, Chapter 44, Section 7(1), as amended, or pursuant to any other enabling authority; and authorize the Select Board to apply for, accept, receive and expend grants, aid, reimbursements, loans, and all other forms of funding and financial assistance from both state and federal sources and agencies for such purpose.

16.) **FREE CASH**: Appropriate and transfer $21,303,316 from free cash for the following purposes:

a.) Operating Budget Reserve Fund (MGL Chapter 40, Section 6) – $853,774
b.) Liability/Catastrophe Fund (Chapter 66 of the Acts of 1998, as amended) – $602,233;
c.) Stabilization Fund (MGL Chapter 40, Section 5B) - $3,500,000
d.) Reduce the tax rate (Special Appropriations) – $14,664,107;
e.) Housing Trust Fund – $1,683,203;

ARTICLE 9 ADVISORY COMMITTEE VOTES

Article Description	**FY 2026 Omnibus Budget**
AC recommendation (Favorable Action unless indicated)	**15-0-0**
Michael Berger	Y
Ben Birnbaum	Y
Harry Bohrs	Y
Cliff Brown	Y
Anthony Buono	
John Doggett	
Katherine Florio	
Harry Friedman *	
David-Marc Goldstein	Y
Neil Gordon	
Susan Granoff	Y
Perry Grossman	Y
Kelly Hardebeck	
Alisa Jonas	Y
Janice Kahn	Y
Alec Lebovitz	
Carol Levin	Y
Pam Lodish	Y
Joslin Murphy	
Donelle O'Neal, Sr.	
Linda Olson Pehlke	Y
Markus Penzel	Y
Fran Perler	Y
David Pollak	Y
Lee Selwyn	
Christine Westphal	
Dennis Doughty	
* Chairperson does not vote except to break a tie	